The Lighthouse Keeper

Chapter One

The lighthouse stood at the edge of the world, or so it seemed to the children who lived in the village below. Every evening the keeper climbed the two hundred and twelve steps to light the great lamp, and every morning he climbed them again to put it out.

Nobody in the village knew his name. They called him the keeper, and that was enough. He had arrived on a grey ship in 1987 with a single suitcase and a cat, and he had never left. The cat, people said, was

older than the lighthouse itself, though that was surely impossible.

One winter a storm came in from the north. The waves rose higher than anyone could remember, and the wind tore the shutters from the houses. That night the lamp went dark.

Chapter Two

In the morning the children ran down to the rocks to see what had happened. The door of the lighthouse stood open, swinging in the wind.

Inside, the stairs were wet with sea spray. At the very top they found the cat, sitting beside the cold lamp, waiting patiently for someone to light it again.

And so, at the age of eleven, Mara became the new keeper.